

1976

1,354 MILES PER HOUR THE TOP SPEED OF CONCORDE



Concorde could travel at more than twice the speed of sound.



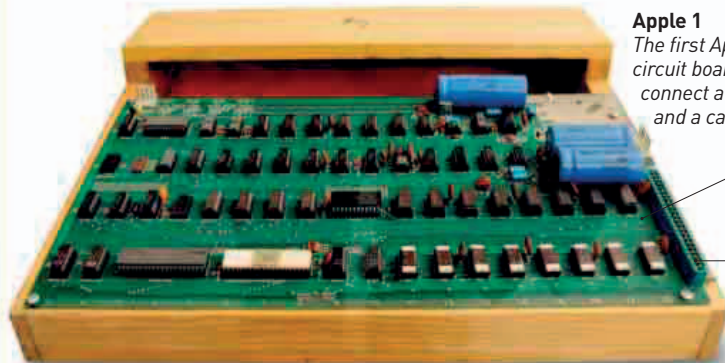
such as mountains, clouds, snowflakes, plants, and lightning bolts as simple repeating patterns on different scales. Mandelbrot's work also fed into the emerging field of **computer graphics**, enabling computer game designers and artists to create stunning **virtual worlds** with realism. With its strong links to another emerging discipline, chaos theory, fractal mathematics helped scientists understand **unpredictable systems**, such as stock markets and earthquakes.

In December, US engineer **Steven Sasson** (b.1950) took the first digital photograph with a device he had invented, which proved to be a prototype of the **digital camera**. Sasson's images had a resolution of just 0.01 megapixels, and took 23 seconds to be stored on magnetic tape.

Also in December, US physicist **Martin Perl** (b.1927) announced the discovery of a subatomic particle that he called **tau lepton**. It was further evidence in favor of the Standard Model of fundamental particles (see 1974). In 1995, Perl was awarded the Nobel Prize in Physics for his discovery.



gamma-ray detector



Apple 1
The first Apple computer came as a single circuit board to which customers would connect a keyboard and a video display, and a cassette player to load programs.

motherboard

cassette board
connector

THE YEAR DAWNED with the maiden flight of **Concorde**, the first supersonic jet airliner. It was developed jointly by British Aerospace (formerly British Aircraft Corporation) and the French company Aérospatiale. After more than 10 years of development and testing, Concorde's **first commercial flights** took place on January 21, one from London to Bahrain and the other from Paris to Rio. Concorde remained in service until 2003. Only one other supersonic airliner has ever gone into service: the Russian Tupolev Tu-144, in 1977. However, it was grounded in 1978 after a crash.

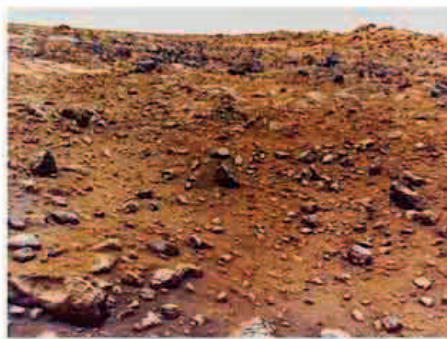
In March, British evolutionary biologist **Richard Dawkins** published *The Selfish Gene*. In it, he suggested that **evolution** was best understood at the **level of genes**, and not whole organisms. The gene-centric theory developed in the 1960s, and it accounts for

certain behaviors that are otherwise hard to explain; for example, the altruism that organisms show toward those most closely related (and therefore likely to carry many of the same genes). Dawkins' use of the word "selfish," although figurative, captured the imagination of the general public and scientists alike. Many consider it to be a landmark in the development of evolutionary biology.

In April, American computer scientists **Steve Jobs** (1955–2011)

and **Steve Wozniak** (b.1950), and electronics expert Ronald Wayne (b.1934) founded a new company called Apple Computers. Their first product, simply called the Apple Computer (later known as **Apple 1**), came as a single circuit board. It had 8 kilobytes of RAM, and sold for \$666.66.

A few months later, US computer company Cray Research delivered a groundbreaking **supercomputer**, **Cray-1**, to the Los Alamos National Laboratory in New Mexico. Cray-1 was the brainchild of Seymour Cray (1925–96), who had been working since the mid-1960s on making processing units work in parallel, to increase computer power.



Surface of Mars
The *Viking* landers, which spent a combined total of 10 years studying the Martian surface, sent back many color pictures to Earth.

In July and September, NASA's unmanned space probes **Viking 1** and **Viking 2** orbited Mars and dropped lander probes on its surface. The landers sent back high resolution images, and also carried out **chemical analyses of the soil**, partly with the aim of finding clues that life had once existed on the planet; however, no such evidence was found.



RICHARD DAWKINS
(b.1941)

British evolutionary biologist Richard Dawkins was born in Kenya, and graduated with a degree in zoology from Oxford University in 1962. For most of the 1960s, he was a researcher in ethology (the study of animal behavior). He has written a number of influential and hugely popular books explaining evolution, criticizing creationism, and promoting atheism.

December Steven Sasson takes the first digital pictures

December Martin Perl announces the discovery of the **tau lepton**

March 16 Publication of Richard Dawkins' *The Selfish Gene*

April 8 Belgian molecular biologist Walter Fiers announces sequencing the entire genome of a virus

June 18 Launch of NASA's Gravity Probe A

July 20 Viking 1 lands on Mars

July The Apple Computer goes on sale; around 200 computers are sold

September Shugart Associates introduce the first 5¼ in (13.3 cm) floppy disk drive

September 9 JVC releases the VHS video system

July The first appearance of the **Ebola virus**, the cause of an infectious disease that has killed thousands

September 3 Viking 2 lands on Mars

September 21 Cray Research delivers Cray-1, the world's most successful supercomputer